50TH ANNIVERSARY

POLITICS
1985-1995

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Mandal and Mandir. It's perhaps no coincidence that they appeared together in history, this double helix on which contemporary India's political genetic code is inscribed. The old 'Congress consensus' had petered out into platitudes; its big tent, which once held all contraries, had collapsed. Around the peripheries of the nation, insurgencies were asserting regional separateness. But these were insurgencies within the main body of the nation—expressing a bristling anger at not being sufficiently accommodated and articulated within the master narratives.

Mandal came as the will to freedom from a long social and economic apartheid. The caste elite felt not a little holy terror at the thought of the 'undeserving' getting a place at the table and disturbing the fine china. Their young added career anxieties to caste hauteur. The blend was inflammable, literally—Rajeev Goswami was only the more photographed one to turn into a pyre.

THE AIR HAD BEEN PRIMED FOR A CONTEMPLATION OF THE MIRACULOUS BY *RAMAYANA* ON TELEVISION. THE AYODHYA MOMENT HAD BEEN SEEDED



The extinguishing of hate is still incomplete, even if, grudgingly, there's a greater acknowledgement that what they saw as innate merit was just inherited social capital. Mandal's greater success is still in the political sphere, where it drew lines in the sand that came to be sacrosanct.

Protagonists of the Mandir, meanwhile, insisted on something else being held sacrosanct. Ideas of the sacred, they said, had been kept out of the secular polity that India became after Independence. Ayodhya was chosen as the place of its reclamation. The air had been made conducive for a contemplation of the miraculous: beginning 1987, a television serial on the Ramayana story had millions transfixed. In real life, L.K. Advani replayed the ashwamedha yagna, letting his rath run across India. It drew legions, seduced by the thought of dismantling a history of trauma, one that was perhaps all the more real for being mostly imagined. Euphoria equalled dysphoria in a zero sum game. ■

SOON, ADVANI WAS REPLAYING THE ASHWAMEDHA YAGNA IN REAL LIFE. IT DREW LEGIONS, SEDUCED BY THE THOUGHT OF DISMANTLING HISTORY